

A

The basis of a discursive essay*

In a discursive essay you have to express your own ideas and **point of view** [opinion]. It is also important to show that you understand **both sides of an argument** [reasons **for** something and reasons **against** something]. This means you need to understand and use different link words and phrases such as **in addition**, **however**, etc. (See [Unit 93](#).)

* an essay that discusses a subject

B

Expressing a point of view

Some people believe [Some people think] that no one should be sent to prison under the age of 18.

There is **an argument** [a reason to think] that everyone should have a university education.

Language **help**

You can express a personal point of view with phrases such as **I believe / think that ...** or **It seems to me that ...** but you can also use less personal and direct ways of expressing a point of view, as in the phrases on the left. Many people think it is better not to use *In my opinion* in written essays.

C

Giving both sides of an argument

One of the advantages of being an only child is that you have more attention from your parents. **However**, it can be lonely without the company of brothers and sisters.

On the one hand, computers can do so many things faster than human beings. **On the other (hand)**, some people are becoming dependent on them, which is not a good thing.

D

Comparing and contrasting*

We often **make comparisons** between groups of people, or between the past and the present. **Compared with / to** my grandparents, I have had much more opportunity to travel abroad.

In the past people didn't have computers, **but nowadays** there is one in almost every home.

Most parts of the developed world have become richer in the last thirty years. **In contrast**, many countries in Africa have become much poorer.

* saying how two things are similar and how they are different

E

Making generalisations

Sometimes a simple statement is not accurate, e.g. *Young people prefer to watch American films*. This is not true for *all* young people, so we use certain words and phrases to show that we are **making a generalisation** [saying that something is true most of the time or in most situations].

In general, Japanese society is more focused on groups than individuals. (*syn on the whole*) Teenagers **tend to** have [usually have] more freedom than in the past.

F

Cause and effect*

Poor diet and lack of exercise are the main **causes of obesity** [reasons for being very fat].

Obesity is often the **result of** a bad diet and not enough exercise.

People don't eat the right food or get enough exercise, and **consequently** [because of this; *syn as a result*] they put on weight.

Poor diet can cause obesity, and this can have a bad **effect on** people's health.

* how something happens, and then makes something else happen

Language **help**

Don't confuse the verb **affect** and the noun **effect**.

*Pollution can **affect** people's breathing.*

*Pollution can **have an effect on** people's breathing.*